

CLASS WP NO. 7161

Imported until 1959, the Class WP was manufactured in India between 1963 and 1967 at the Chittaranjan Locomotive Works (CLW) of West Bengal. The heritage locomotive Class WP No. 7161 was built in 1965 to run on the Northeast Frontier Railway. It is now based at the Rewari Steam Locomotive Shed, where it was named *Akbar* after the third Mughal Emperor (1556–1605).

A LEAGUE OF ITS OWN

When the Class WP of sleek, bullet-nosed, mainline steam locomotives was first introduced, it set the standard for the Indian Railways and became the mainstay of broad-gauge passenger operations for the rest of the 20th century. Known for free steaming, high fuel economy, superior riding characteristics, and without the tail wag of the earlier X classes, its arrival marked the change of the broad-gauge coding from X to W.

The first 16 Class WP steam locomotives – W for the 1.67-m-broad gauge and P for passenger – arrived in India in 1947 from the Baldwin Locomotive Works in the US. However, in 1963–67, 259 engines were built in the CLW. Requiring a crew of three – a driver and two firemen – these locomotives hauled most of the prestigious passenger trains on the Indian rail system for the next 25 years. They established a sound reputation during their time in service, with their good performance earning them the title “Pride of the Fleet”.